

U&i TWS-9009

Lacks outright performance, but one for the early-adopters

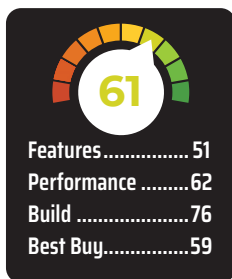
The news of Apple making a pair of TWS earbuds with a screen to expand their AirPods lineup was all the rage recently when they updated their patents, adding to the list of features and inclusions. While Apple's offering still remains a pipe dream for the brand, there are other offerings that take inspiration from their vision and are in to capture their share of the market before Apple announces their products. One such offering from a relatively unknown brand, U&i, popped on our radar recently. It is called the U&i TWS-9009, also dubbed Century series TWS.

I called for these earbuds to be tested at the Digit Test Centre and take a closer look at what Apple's offering, whenever it becomes a reality, would look like. Another reason for calling these earbuds for a review was their price. I am fully aware that there's a much more solid concept of a pair of TWS that exists in the form of the JBL LIVE BEAM 3. I would definitely try and get my hands on them soon; however, priced at ₹13,999 and coming from a brand like JBL, I know they will do well. I wanted to know what a relatively new player in the market, pricing their earbuds at ₹3,999, would be able to pull off. And, to be honest, when I got my hands on these earbuds, I had a mixed bag of feelings. I will not spill the beans here. Read along to find out how the U&i TWS-9009 fared in my testing –

BUILD AND DESIGN

Saying that these earbuds take inspiration from Apple's current line of AirPods would be an understatement. As you can see in the image below, the basic

₹3,999



case and earbud design of these earbuds is heavily borrowed from the AirPods. The small indent on the case where the branding has been screened on to the case is the only thing that would distinguish these earbuds from the AirPods.

The buds are also very similarly designed when compared to the AirPods.

They have the same oblong bud, and the stem has the same silver accents as the AirPods. I compared the size of these earbuds by fitting them into the case of my Apple AirPods Pro Gen2 and found them to be slightly bigger than the AirPods. However, the overall fit and experience are very similar to those of AirPods. So, if you have a pair of AirPods Pro that fits you well, then you can stay assured about the fit of these earbuds, too. However, there are no additional ear tips in the box. You get a U&i branded lanyard with the earbuds. Something to

put through the metallic lanyard loop on the case!

In terms of the build quality of the buds and the case, I was pleasantly surprised. The case is well-built and has a nice heft to it. You also get a metallic hinge, and the screen, which has a plastic face, also did not pick up many scratches during my time of use.

Same is the case with the earbuds.

U&i pretty much nailed the fit and finish of their 9009 TWS earbuds. For the price of ₹3,999 these earbuds do not lack quality in terms of their build and choice of materials.

Even though the overall design language of the buds is pretty much the same as that of the AirPods and would have many people question the overall quality of the buds, given the standards set by other earbuds that have taken inspiration from Apple, these earbuds deliver over and above the expectations that anyone would have from these earbuds.

FEATURES

The biggest, and honestly, the only standout feature of the U&i TWS-9009 is the screen that has been baked into the case of the buds. It is incredibly functional and smooth. You can control the following features from the screen itself –

1. Music playback and volume
2. ANC
3. Equaliser (Customisable)
4. Low latency mode
5. Use the screen as a flashlight
6. Audio and camera recording trigger, and a couple of other things, including changing the wallpaper of the buds.

The controls are very responsive, and I did not notice any bugs or glitches in the interface during my time of use. My favourite part of the screen is that it has customisable brightness, which means I have another level of control over the battery consumption of the buds. Talking about the battery, the battery life of the buds and the case is neatly displayed in one corner of the screen.